

What Is Religion?

When does life begin and end? Where is heaven? If there is a god who is loving and omnipotent, or all-knowing, why do pain and suffering exist in the world today? Do human beings have free will, or is all of life predestined by God's will? These are questions that many human beings consider at some point in their lives. Some people answer these questions based on their religious belief or faith. In fact, the definition of **religion** is a set of beliefs attempting to answer life's ultimate questions for which human beings have no definitive or scientific explanation.

Religion plays a significant role in culture because it is through religious teachings that people derive their moral compass, a set of rules by which people live their lives. Most people will filter their daily decisions of eating, working, and personal relationships through their religious beliefs. These individual decisions will be pooled together in a community until there is a general expectation about roles each person should play, how people should dress, how they should behave, and the general character of the community.

There are some people, however, who do not adhere to any religious beliefs. People who believe there is no god are called **atheists**. Another group of people called **agnostics** have some general acknowledgment of a "higher power" but do not embrace the definitions or full beliefs of those who belong to an organized religion.

It is important to remember that when discussing culture, one must maintain the ability to make generalizations. There are always exceptions to the rules. This lesson will address generally accepted teachings of each major organized mainstream religion and will not specify exceptions to the generalizations.

All major religions share the following general characteristics:

- Belief in a deity (god) or deities (gods) who created the heavens and the Earth, is the source of all life, and will sit in final judgment of human beings once they die;
- Rules or laws; it is believed that if a follower of religion will live his or her life by these rules or laws, they will be rewarded with salvation or eternal life (although different religions define these things in different contexts);
- Sacred text that contains teachings of the religion and may include a written history of the religion;
- Doctrine of salvation, or what to expect when the earthly body dies, which is outlined and explained in the sacred text; and
- Rituals and/or ceremonies to commemorate significant events in the life of their followers.

Major world religions can be divided into two main categories. **Universal religions** are those that try to appeal to all people. The religion's followers actively attempt to convert people to their belief system, regardless of location. Universal religions include Christianity, Islam, Buddhism, and Sikhism. **Ethnic religions** are based on

IR-23: What Is Religion?

a set of physical characteristics and have a more limited spatial distribution pattern. In other words, the ethnic religions of Judaism and Hinduism tend not to actively convert people. Rather, most Jews and Hindus believe that one is born as a Jew or Hindu; one cannot convert to their belief system.

Christianity is based on the teachings of Jesus Christ beginning in about 33 AD. It has the most adherents worldwide, accounting for about 33% of the total world population. Christians can be found in every major culture region but tend to be clustered the most in Western Europe, Eastern Europe, the United States, Canada, Central America, and South America. There are many different denominations within Christianity, including Roman Catholic, Protestant (e.g., Baptist, Methodist, Lutheran, Presbyterian, Anglican, and Pentecostal), and Eastern Orthodox.

The two main characteristics that set Christians apart from other believers is that they believe that Jesus Christ was the Messiah (meaning “savior”) and that he arose from the dead. All other major religions acknowledge that Jesus walked the Earth; that he was Jewish; that he taught in **synagogues**, or Jewish sacred temples; and that he was crucified on a cross.

The building where Christians go to worship is a **sacred space**. Christians regard the building as a holy space that has religious significance. There are three types of buildings in which Christians gather. The first is a **church**. A church usually is built in a community and serves the people in that local area. The second type of building is a **basilica**. For Catholics, this is a building that has specific religious significance as designated by the Pope. A final Christian structure, also unique to Catholics, is called a **cathedral**, which is the location of the bishop.



St. Peter's Basilica in Vatican City is the main church of the Pope, who is the spiritual leader of Catholics.



The Holy Bible contains the historical foundations of Christianity (Old Testament) as well as the teachings of Jesus (New Testament).

Christians follow a moral code called Mosaic Law, or the Ten Commandments, which Moses delivered to the people on Mount Sinai. Christians' sacred text is the **Holy Bible**, which is divided into two sections called the Old Testament and the New Testament. Christians believe that God will judge their souls on the final judgment day and that they either will be rewarded with eternal salvation by going to heaven or will be punished by going to hell. Common rituals or ceremonies shared by most Christians include baptism (symbolic washing away of sin) and communion (commemorating the Last Supper).

IR-23: What Is Religion?

The first known writing about **Islam** was in 622 AD, when Muhammad, the most important **prophet** to those who believe in Islam, stopped trading goods throughout the Red Sea and began teaching about Allah. Islam, which literally means "submission to God," is the second largest religious group in the world, accounting for approximately 21% of all the people in the world. Followers of Islam are called **Muslims**;

the word *Muslim* literally means "one who submits." The largest concentration of Muslims can be found throughout Southwest Asia and Northern Africa. As a universal religion, Islam is like Christianity in that it actively seeks converts and can be found in every cultural region throughout the world.

FIVE PILLARS OF FAITH

1. There is no God but Allah, and Muhammad is His Prophet.
2. Pray five times a day facing Mecca.
3. Give alms to the poor.
4. Make a pilgrimage to Mecca at least once in life if possible.
5. Fast during Ramadan.



The Ka'aba, the big black square structure in the middle of the Great Mosque in Mecca, is the focal point of Muslims who make a pilgrimage to Mecca.

There are two main branches of Islam. The **Sunni** branch of Islam accounts for the majority of Muslims, and they are more widely distributed throughout the world. The **Shi'a** branch, a more conservative group that follows a more literal interpretation of Islam, is found primarily in Iran. The major difference between these two groups of Muslims is political rather than religious. There was not a written order of succession after Muhammad. Once he died, there was a conflict between the two groups as to who would become the leader of Islam.

Muslims believe the same teachings as Jews and Christians beginning with the creation of the world, including Adam and Eve, Noah and the flood, and Abraham. However, it is with the story of Abraham sacrificing his son at God's request that Muslims begin to differ from Jews and Christians, who believe that Isaac was the son Abraham was going to sacrifice. Muslims believe that the son was Ishmael, not Isaac.

From this point onward, Muslims have different teachings and traditions. Some of these different teachings include a belief in the Five Pillars of Faith in addition to the Ten Commandments. A **mosque** is a building where Muslims can gather for prayers, but it is not a sacred space as a church is for Christians. The **Qur'an** is the sacred text for Muslims. It is written in Arabic and is divided into **suras**, or chapters. Each sura begins with the Muslims' profession of faith: "There is no God but Allah, and Muhammad is His Prophet." Muslims have a well-defined belief in life after death. Like Christians and Jews, Muslims believe that Allah will sit in judgment and determine if they will be rewarded by going to paradise (heaven) or hell.

IR-23: What Is Religion?

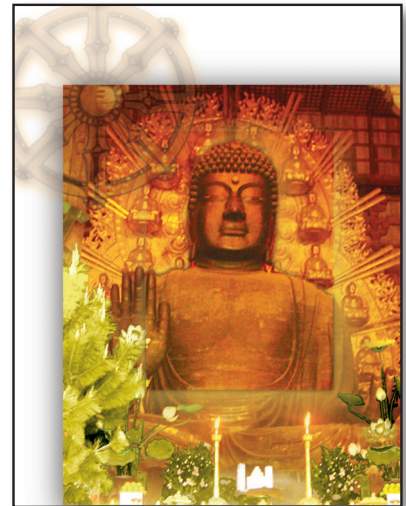


The Qur'an is written in Arabic and is read from right to left. It contains the teachings of the prophet Muhammad.

Two rituals that help to define Muslim customs and tradition include the hajj and Ramadan. The **hajj** is a pilgrimage Muslims are required to make to Mecca, Saudi Arabia, at least once in their lifetime if possible. This faith journey must be paid for in advance by the person going on the trip. The person must be a Muslim in good standing in the community, attested to by the leader of the local mosque. Once in Mecca, the hajj takes about 1 week to complete. Every day there are certain prayers and rituals that are performed, and Muslims talk about the solemnity and solidarity they experience during their pilgrimage.

The other ritual Muslims perform is fasting during Ramadan. **Ramadan** is the ninth month of the Islamic calendar, a time Muslims believe Muhammad had a vision of an archangel, or a high-ranking angel, who convinced him to start teaching Allah's word. Accordingly, during the month, a period of 30 days, Muslims will observe a complete and total fast from sunrise to sunset. They will not eat or drink anything during daylight hours; only after the sun sets will Muslims eat and drink. However, they will still go to school or work. As with most religious rituals, this requirement will be waived for the very young, the elderly, or anyone who is ill.

Another universal religion is **Buddhism**, which grew out of Hinduism about 500 BC, much the same way Christianity has its foundation in Judaism. Buddhists account for about 6% of the total population of the world. There are two main denominations of Buddhism. The Mahayana is the larger of the two groups and can be found primarily throughout the northern parts of East Asia, including but not limited to northern India, Tibet, China, South Korea, and Japan. Theravada is the smaller division of Buddhism and is located across southern India, Sri Lanka, Thailand, Cambodia, and Vietnam.



A statue of Buddha sitting in the lotus position reflects a peaceful, meditative state that Buddhists try to emulate.



The Dalai Lama travels the world seeking international aid in resisting what he believes to be cultural genocide against his people.

The Tibetan city of Lhasa is recognized as the holiest city for and center of Buddhist beliefs. The **Dalai Lama** is the spiritual and political leader of Buddhism, and he lives in exile in northern India as a result of a political and military conflict between Chinese communists and Tibetan Buddhists. Buddhists live all over the world, but the highest concentration can be found in East and Southeast Asia.

IR-23: What Is Religion?

Buddhists believe in a code of conduct called the **Eight Fold Path**, which is symbolized by an eight-spoke wheel. These eight rules are similar to the Ten Commandments.

Comparison of Buddhist and Judaic Tenets

Eight Fold Path*	Ten Commandments**
Right View	"Thou shalt have no other gods before me."
Right Intention	"Thou shalt not make unto thee any graven image, or any likeness of any thing that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth."
Right Speech	"Thou shalt not take the name of the Lord thy God in vain."
Right Action	"Remember the sabbath day, to keep it holy."
Right Livelihood	"Honor thy father and thy mother."
Right Effort	"Thou shalt not kill."
Right Mindfulness	"Thou shalt not commit adultery."
Right Concentration	"Thou shalt not steal."
	"Thou shalt not bear false witness against thy neighbor."
	"Thou shalt not covet thy neighbor's house, thou shalt not covet thy neighbor's wife, nor his manservant, nor his maidservant, nor his ox, nor his ass, nor any thing that is thy neighbor's."

*Knierim, T. (2013). The noble eightfold path. In *TheBigView.com*. Retrieved from www.thebigview.com/buddhism/eightfoldpath.html

**Bartleby.com. (2000). The ten commandments (Exodus 20:3–17). *The holy bible: King James version*. Retrieved from www.bartleby.com/108/02/20.html

The Eight Fold Path is found in the **Tripitaka**, the sacred text for most Buddhists. Buddhists have different explanations of salvation mostly because of the two main denominations. However, both groups believe in **reincarnation**, the rebirth of a soul into another life-form, depending on how well one lived his or her current life. A common Buddhist ritual is that of **meditation**, a silent and personal period of reflection or prayer. Buddhists have a strong belief that meditation and self-reflection are the best way to follow the Eight Fold Path, which will help them to find enlightenment.

IR-23: What Is Religion?

Sikhism is the smallest of the universalizing religions, with about 23 million believers, yet it ranks as the fifth largest religion in overall adherents. Sikhism began in the middle of the 15th century in the Punjab region of northern India. The most sacred place for Sikhs is the Golden Temple in Amritsar, India, which is in the Punjab region. This remains the largest concentration of **Sikhs**, believers in Sikhism, but growing concentrations of Sikhs can also be found in the United Kingdom and the United States. The word Sikh translates to “disciple.” Guru Nanak started teaching about this monotheistic religion shortly after receiving the divine revelation. A **guru** is an inspired religious leader.

The tenets of Sikhism can be found in their sacred text, called the Guru Granth Sahib, which is a collection of poems and hymns. These lessons include instructions on how to

- live a good and moral life,
- treat all human beings equally,
- promote social justice,
- encourage loyalty,
- show gratitude for receiving favors from others,
- show compassion and be philanthropic, and
- resist believing in superstitions and practicing blind rituals.

In everyday life, Sikhs are taught to be self-reliant. Sikhs have a long tradition of being industrious workers in all walks of life as farmers, laborers, doctors, entertainers, and engineers. Sikhs also have a strong sense of justice when called to action, protecting anyone from harm.



Race and ethnicity encompass physical characteristics and can be observed visually, whereas culture is a way of life that is acquired.

The terms *race*, *culture*, and *ethnicity* sometimes are used synonymously. However, these terms have different meanings and should not be used interchangeably. Race refers to genetic characteristics of people such as the color of one’s skin, hair, and eyes, as well as other physical characteristics such as facial features. Race is always inherited. As you have already discovered, **culture** is defined as the way of life of a group of people. Culture is not

inherited but acquired. **Ethnicity** encompasses physical characteristics of people as well as cultural similarities. For example, there is tremendous ethnic diversity within countries such as the United States, Canada, Germany, and Russia because there are people with extremely different physical and cultural characteristics. Some of these differing characteristics include different eye shapes, forehead shapes, skin color, hair color, spoken language, types of food eaten, and styles of clothing.

IR-23: What Is Religion?

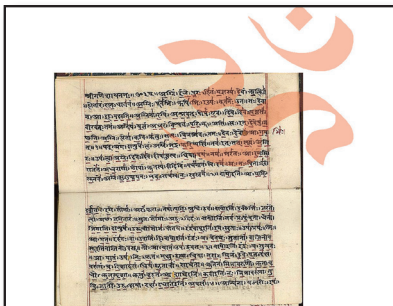
The ethnic religion that has the largest number of followers is **Hinduism**. Hinduism is the only major religion that did not evolve from the teachings of any single person. It started in the lower Indus River valley about 1500 BC and accounts for about 13% of the total population of the world, with most Hindus living primarily in India. In fact, during the British partitioning of India in 1947, the Indian subcontinent was divided based on religious affiliation. The current country of India was set aside for Hindus, while East Pakistan (now known as Bangladesh) and West Pakistan (now known as Pakistan) were designated as Muslim homelands. About 85% of all Hindus in the world live in present-day India.

Hindus believe in a trinity of gods. **Brahma** is viewed as the Creator, the source of everything in life. **Shiva**, the Destroyer, is seen as death, which is a part of life. **Vishnu**, the Preserver, represents the rebirth of life after death. Hindu teachings consider both Shiva and Vishnu to be incarnations of Brahma, resulting in the Hindu belief that these three gods are all the same entity.



Hindu gods are known as a trinity. What other religion includes a trinity of gods?

Because Hindus proclaim a belief in more than one god, people in the Western world look at Hindus as being **polytheistic**. However, Hindus consider themselves to be **monotheistic**, or believing in only one god, just as Christians do who believe in a similar concept where there is a God the father, God the son, and God the holy spirit, mysteriously three separate entities and yet existing as one.



Hindus believe that most, if not all, hymns and rituals contained in the Vedas are still relevant to today's society, making the teachings and traditions of Hinduism unique and practical.

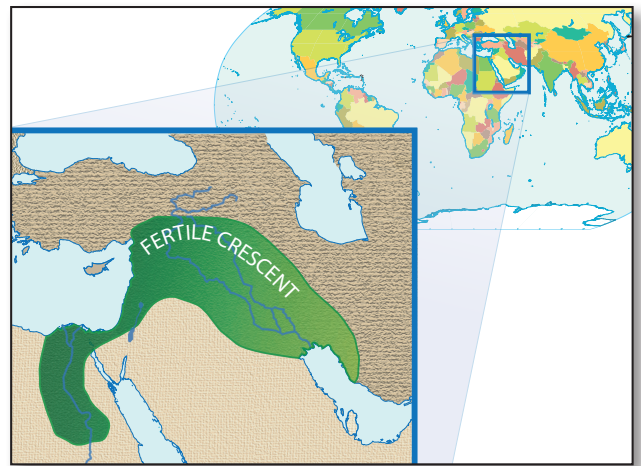
Hindus do not have a universal set of rules they follow, but a pervasive belief for Hindus is that all life is sacred. Most Hindus are vegetarian because they do not believe in slaughtering animals for human consumption. The sacred text for Hindus is called the **Vedas**, a collection that is believed to have been revealed directly to ancient Indians and that is considered the scriptural authority of Hinduism.

Hindus believe in the concept of reincarnation, a form of life after death. Hindu beliefs of salvation are based on the ideas of dharma and karma. **Dharma** can be defined as deeds done right now, in this lifetime, which will follow the believer into the next life and will be the basis of the quality of the believer's future life. **Karma**, on the other hand, is the idea that consequences of actions from a previous lifetime dictate one's current life. In other words, dharma influences karma. Karma is not necessarily positive or negative; it simply depends on the person's actions.

IR-23: What Is Religion?

Judaism is one of the oldest organized religions today. It is a complex system that incorporates religious teachings as well as political influences from Israel, the only official Jewish nation in the world. Jewish teachings go back to about 2000 BC with Abraham following God's command to move to the region of Canaan, which is near present-day Israel and Lebanon. This land is known as "**the Promised Land**," since Jews (as well as Christians and Muslims) believe that this land was promised to them by God as a result of Abraham obeying God's commandment.

Today there are about 14 million Jews worldwide, which accounts for less than 1% of the total world population. Jews are found primarily in the country of Israel (7.4 million), with other Jews scattered throughout Europe and the United States. The largest concentration of Jews outside Israel can be found in New York City.



This part of the world is home to the three Abrahamic religions. Conflicts in this region include disputes over natural resources (water and oil in particular) as well as land that each religion considers sacred.

There are three different denominations of Judaism:

- **Orthodox Jews** have the most traditional interpretation of the Jewish faith. They adamantly believe that you cannot convert to Judaism. Rather, you are born a Jew, and with that, you have serious responsibilities associated with being a Jew.
- **Reform Jews** are the most liberal Jews. This designation is not a political description; rather, in the traditional sense of the word *liberal*, Reform Jews are open-minded toward people who were not born to a Jewish mother. They also tend not to be bound by traditional points of view held by Orthodox Jews. Reform Jews tend to welcome people who are interested in converting to Judaism.
- **Conservative Jews** fall between Orthodox and Reform Jews, maintaining some traditional guidelines while accepting a more modern interpretation, yet they are not as liberal as Reform Jews.

Ethical monotheism is the revolutionary belief that Judaism brought to the religious world. Until the teachings of Abraham and Moses were established, there was not a religion that taught about the existence of one god (in Hebrew, "YHWH") who demanded that people follow ethical or correct behavior. Because this was such a different idea, this may explain, in part, why Jews have been persecuted for a longer period of time than any other religious group. Ethical monotheism presented a radically different idea beyond what people were willing to accept.

Jews and Christians share many of the same beliefs: the existence of only one god, doing good deeds, and living life according to the Ten Commandments. The main

IR-23: What Is Religion?

difference is that Christians believe that Jesus was the Messiah, and Jews are still awaiting the Messiah.

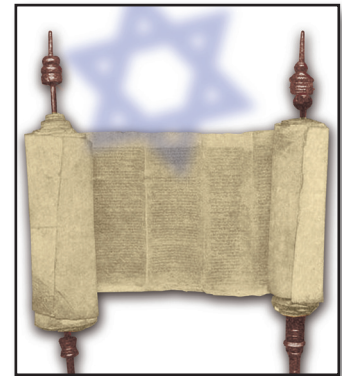
The **Torah** is recognized as the written text handed down from YHWH to Moses on Mount Sinai. Jews also believe that the **Talmud** is a sacred text, but it is the oral history and tradition of the Jewish faith. Jews, like Christians and Muslims, believe that God will judge people on the final judgment day and that good people will be rewarded with eternal salvation in heaven while bad people will suffer in hell.



In a bat mitzvah, a 12-year-old girl is called to read from the Torah.

Two well-known rituals in the Jewish faith are the **bar mitzvah** for boys and the **bat mitzvah** for girls. These terms mean becoming a

“son or daughter of the commandment.” From this point onward, Jewish youth are to obey the commandments under Jewish law. These ceremonies occur when boys turn 13 and girls turn 12, respectively, and signify that these young people are entering adulthood within the Jewish faith.



The Torah contains God’s laws and is interpreted strictly. It was originally written in the Aramaic language.

Sources

Adherents.com. (2013). *Major religions of the world ranked by number of adherents*. Retrieved from www.adherents.com/Religions_By_Adherents.html

BBC Religions. (2013). *Five pillars of Islam*. Retrieved from www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/islam/practices/fivepillars.shtml

Greiner, A L. (2010). *Visualizing human geography: At home in a diverse world* (1st ed.). Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons, Inc.

Harper, J. (2012, December 23). 84 percent of the world population has faith; a third are Christian. *Washington Times*. Retrieved from www.washingtontimes.com/blog/watercooler/2012/dec/23/84-percent-world-population-has-faith-third-are-ch/

Islam 101. (n.d.). *Five pillars of Islam*. Retrieved from www.islam101.com/dawah/pillars.html

PBS.org. *Five pillars*. (1995–2013). Retrieved from www.pbs.org/empires/islam/faithpillars.html

Royal Embassy of Saudi Arabia. (2013). *About Saudi Arabia: The five pillars of Islam*. Retrieved from www.saudiembassy.net/about/country-information/Islam/five_pillars_of_Islam.aspx